



Logged as Reflection: An Interview Study of What Happens Inside a Booked Wellbeing Pod

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Abstract. Student Wellbeing installed forty single-occupant reflection pods across campus over the past year, bookable through the same interface used for meeting rooms, with each completed booking feeding a wellbeing-engagement tile on the School of Continuous Improvement's Living Dashboard. The tile treats a booking as a proxy for restorative use; nothing about what happens once the door closes is otherwise recorded. We conducted semi-structured exit interviews with 64 students shortly after a pod booking across one twelve-week term, and coded what they reported doing into a six-category taxonomy. Reflection or mindfulness practice — the single reason the intake form asks a student to name before a slot is confirmed — accounted for a minority of coded sessions; the modal use was coursework, followed by a private phone call and, in roughly a fifth of sessions, sleep. Midway through the term, the intake form was revised to drop the mandatory reason field for a second cohort; neither the coded activity mix nor median session duration shifted detectably between the two cohorts, while the engagement tile continued climbing regardless, rising 31% across the term. We discuss what a completed booking can and cannot stand in for once occupancy, not activity, is the thing being counted.

Introduction

Demand for low-threshold, in-person mental-health infrastructure on campus has grown alongside rising documented need: recent multi-country surveys estimate that a substantial minority of incoming university students meet criteria for at least one mental disorder in the past year [1], and formal counselling services remain under-used relative to that need even where they are free at the point of access [2]. Universities have responded partly by expanding formal counselling capacity and partly by seeding campus-wide, unstaffed infrastructure — quiet rooms, sensory pods, and similar single-occupant spaces — intended to lower the threshold for a restorative break between classes. A parallel research tradition treats brief access to a restorative environment as valuable in itself, independent of formal treatment: exposure to a low-stimulation setting has been linked to attention recovery and stress reduction in both clinical and everyday campus settings

[3], [4], with campus-specific work identifying where students already choose to take an informal study break and why [5].

Slop University's Student Wellbeing service installed forty single-occupant reflection pods across campus over the past year. A booking is made through the same interface used for meeting rooms and requires a single field — “reason for booking,” chosen from a short list headed by “reflection / mindfulness” — before a slot is confirmed. Every completed booking, of any stated reason and regardless of what happens during it, is counted toward a wellbeing-engagement tile on the School of Continuous Improvement's Living Dashboard. To our knowledge, no prior work has checked what a completed booking of this kind actually captures once a student is inside and the door has closed.

This paper reports an interview-based audit of that gap. Our contributions:

- We build a coded taxonomy of what students report doing inside a booked reflection

pod, from semi-structured exit interviews conducted shortly after 64 bookings across one term.

- We exploit a mid-term revision to the intake form, which dropped the mandatory reason field for a second cohort, as a natural-experiment ablation, and find neither the activity mix nor session duration shifts detectably between cohorts.
- We set the coded taxonomy and the ablation against the Living Dashboard's own wellbeing-engagement tile over the same term, and find the tile rises steadily throughout, unaffected by either the form revision or by how little of the coded activity resembles the reason a booking is filed under.

Related work

A substantial literature supports the premise that brief access to a low-stimulation environment restores attention and lowers measured stress, from hospital recovery settings [3] through general integrative accounts of restorative environments [6] to naturalistic sound exposure [4]; campus-specific work has gone further and asked where students already choose to take an informal break and what predicts the choice [5]. A separate sleep literature establishes that a short daytime nap, even one lasting under twenty minutes, measurably improves alertness and mood [7], with benefits that vary by nap length and time of day [8] — both plausible, and largely uninvestigated, explanations for what an occupied reflection pod is actually doing for the student inside it.

None of this literature, to our knowledge, audits what a booking of this kind is used for against what an institution counts it as. That question sits closer to a distinct tradition on measurement reactivity: a chosen indicator tends to distort the process it is meant to track once the process is optimised toward the indicator rather than the outcome [9], an effect popularly generalised across many measurement settings [10] and observed directly in public-sector target regimes [11] and in the reactive effects of public rankings on the institutions ranked by them [12]. Broader accounts of indicators in governance [13], of real-time urban dashboards as a genre [14], and of performance-measurement design generally [15] converge on the same caution: a count is only as informative as what it was built to distinguish, and an institution's own use of a

count can outrun what the count was ever validated to mean — itself a case of a measurement producing consequences its designers did not anticipate [16].

Method

Student Wellbeing's forty pods were installed progressively over the preceding twelve months and reached full deployment at the start of the term we study. Each pod seats one person, is bookable in 15-minute increments up to 45 minutes through the University's shared room-booking system, and requires the booker to select a reason from a five-item list before the booking is confirmed; "reflection / mindfulness" is listed first. Every confirmed booking, regardless of stated reason, increments the week's count feeding the Living Dashboard's wellbeing-engagement tile, reported as booked slots over available slots.

We recruited interview participants by approaching students as they left a pod across a twelve-week term, inviting a five-minute semi-structured exit interview on what they had just done inside. 64 students agreed: 34 in weeks 1-6, while the reason field remained mandatory, and 30 in weeks 7-12, after an unrelated intake-form revision dropped the field for new bookings while leaving the pods and booking window unchanged. We treat this revision as a natural-experiment ablation of the reason field's effect on pod use. Two coders independently applied thematic analysis [17] to the interview transcripts, converging on a six-category taxonomy (coursework, private phone call, napping, between-class gap, reflection or mindfulness, other) after a first coding pass; disagreements were resolved by discussion, with substantial inter-rater agreement on the resulting categories ($\kappa = 0.79$). Because our activity codes rest on student self-report rather than direct observation, we treat them as a lower bound on the diversity of undisclosed uses and note the general risk that self-reported behaviour diverges from enacted behaviour in exactly the direction a respondent expects to be judged favourably [18].

Results

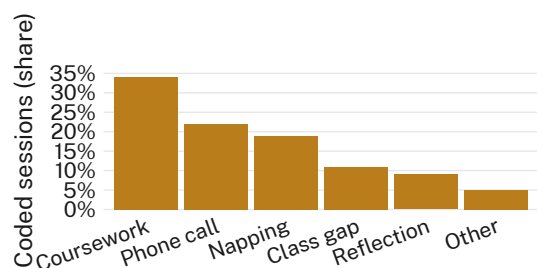


Figure 1: Coursework was the modal coded activity (34% of sessions, $n = 64$); reflection or mindfulness, the reason a booking is filed under, accounted for 9%.

Figure 1 summarises the coded taxonomy across all 64 interviews. Coursework was the single largest category at 34% of sessions, followed by a private phone call (22%) and napping (19%); reflection or mindfulness — the reason listed first on the intake form, and the only reason a booking can be filed under before Wellbeing counts it as engagement — accounted for 9% of coded sessions, tied with sessions students described as simply filling a gap between classes (11%) once the remaining 5% of miscellaneous uses are set aside.

Figure 2 reports the reason-field ablation. Median session duration was 14 minutes in both the mandatory-field cohort (weeks 1-6, $n = 34$) and the dropped-field cohort (weeks 7-12, $n = 30$), with overlapping interquartile ranges in both groups (Mann-Whitney U , $p = 0.71$); the coded activity mix shifted by no more than three percentage points in any category between cohorts.

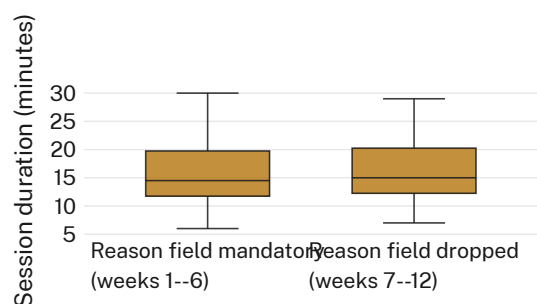


Figure 2: Session duration is statistically indistinguishable between the cohort booked while the reason field was mandatory and the cohort booked after it was dropped ($p = 0.71$).

Figure 3 plots the Living Dashboard's wellbeing-engagement tile across the same term. The tile rose from 48% of available slots booked in week

1 to 63% in week 12 — a 31% relative increase — climbing at an indistinguishable rate before and after the week 7 form revision that dropped the reason field entirely.

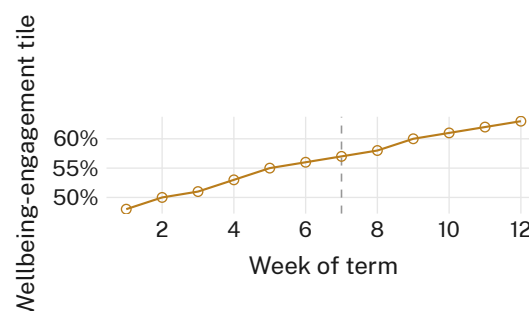


Figure 3: The wellbeing-engagement tile rose from 48% to 63% of available slots across the term (+31%), with no detectable change in growth rate after the week 7 intake-form revision.

Discussion

Across a twelve-week term, the fraction of reflection-pod sessions coded as resembling their stated reason stayed a minority throughout, the reason field's removal changed neither what a pod was used for nor how long a booking ran, and the metric built to track uptake of the pods rose regardless, on a trajectory that shows no trace of either finding. Read against the reactivity literature, this is closer to a case in which a proxy count has already fully decoupled from the behaviour it was meant to index than to one where a count is merely a noisy but improvable stand-in [9], [10]: dropping the one field that still asked a student to name a reason changed nothing measurable about either the count or what actually happened inside, which suggests the field was recording an intention at the point of booking rather than shaping, or even describing, the behaviour that followed. We do not read this as evidence the pods are failing students — students catching up on coursework, taking a private call, or sleeping in a quiet room between classes may be getting exactly the restorative break the infrastructure was built to enable, plausibly consistent with what shorter naps are already known to do for alertness [7], [8]. What the tile cannot tell the Living Dashboard, or anyone reading it, is which of those two things a rising number represents.

Limitations

Our interview sample is drawn from a single term at a single institution, and participation required a student to agree to a five-minute conversation immediately after leaving a pod, which may under-sample students whose pod use they would rather not describe — though the wide spread of activities students did volunteer, including several coded as private phone calls made moments after declining to elaborate further, suggests the sample was not confined to the most flattering uses. The reason-field ablation was not randomised; it coincided with a scheduled form revision, though the revision's timing was set by an unrelated procurement cycle and unconnected to any known change in pod demand, supporting a natural-experiment reading. $\kappa = 0.79$ leaves room for category disagreement at the margins, though the coarse pattern — that coursework, calls, and sleep together outnumber reflection several times over — is not sensitive to where individual borderline sessions land.

Conclusion

Interviewing 64 students shortly after a reflection-pod booking, we find that coursework, private phone calls, and napping together account for three-quarters of coded sessions, against a 9% share for the reflection or mindfulness activity a booking must be filed under before it counts. Dropping the intake form's reason field entirely changed neither the coded activity mix nor session duration, while the Living Dashboard's wellbeing-engagement tile climbed steadily throughout regardless. A booking count built to track uptake of a wellbeing intervention appears, on this evidence, to track occupancy of a quiet room with a door that closes. Future work might extend the same interview-based audit to the University's other single-occupant bookable spaces, and test whether an activity-blind count can be redesigned to distinguish restorative use from any other reason a student might want ten uninterrupted minutes alone.

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